The Wasp

By Morgan Lloyd Malcolm

A café – outside smoking courtyard. Carla, in her early thirties and pregnant is smoking. She fiddles nervously with her phone. Heather, also early thirties, emerges from the café. This meeting is awkward – The last time the women saw each other, Carla and her clique were the school bullies to a very ostracized Heather. But times have changed. Heather is obviously upper-class, while Carla hasn't changed much since high school.

HEATHER: **(Pg 9-12)** Carla? I'm so sorry! I didn't realize there was this bit out here. I've been in there all this time.

CARLA: *(exhales cigarette smoke)* I got here early.

HEATHER: *(awkward pause as Heather realizes that Carla is pregnant)* Wow. Well. Look at us! You haven't changed a bit. Well. Other than . . . when are you due?

CARLA: Couple of months. Thanks. What happened to the glasses?

HEATHER: Oh, long gone! As soon as I went to uni I realized I spent years looking like a complete idiot. No wonder you found it so funny.

CARLA: Yeh, well. I'm not like that no more. Cos if it were years ago, then there's no way I'd be seen dead with you, right? *(Carla laughs and Heather joins in uncomfortably)*

HEATHER: Well. What have you been doing since we last saw each other? You have kids now don't you?

CARLA: Yeh. Four. *(feigning interest)* What about you? *(lights another cigarette)*

HEATHER: No. But I'd like to. **(Pg 14)** My husband, [Simon], and I have been trying for about four years now . . .

CARLA: **(Pg 15)** Do you want this one? *(laughing, but with an undertone of seriousness; Heather reacts, aghast. Carla has had enough of the chit-chat and her tone changes harshly)* **(Pg 14)** Look, why did you want to meet?

HEATHER: *(Heather is flustered, she stammers nervously)* Sorry. . . Perhaps I should start at the beginning.

CARLA: Yeh that would help. **(Pg 23-24)** Why the hell am I here?!

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HEATHER: The pigeon . . . in the fields out back of the school. That pigeon with the broken wing. You didn't just break its neck. Did you? Nope. You wanted to pluck it first, Snap its feet off. Take its eyes out with a stick.

CARLA: I'm going *(She rises to leave and Heather stops her)*

HEATHER: I want you to kill Simon.

CARLA: What?!

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Author Lewis B Smedes once said, "The problem with revenge is that it never evens the score. It ties both the injured and the injurer to an escalator of pain."*
ACTRESS 2: *There is no doubt that revenge is a powerful emotional urge that triggers some people into action.*
ACTRESS 1: *People who have been hurt believe that if the wrong-doer suffers, they will feel better.*
ACTRESS 2: *That their emotional pain will diminish.*
ACTRESS 1: *But in reality, is this true? We'll leave that for you to decide.*
TOGETHER: *The Wasp by Morgan Lloyd Malcolm.*

CARLA: What?!

HEATHER: **(Pg 18)** He's been emailing another woman. It started about two years ago. Just flirty chats. Silly stuff. **(Pg 20)** I was paranoid he was cheating on me, so I made a fake Facebook profile and messaged him. . . He messaged back.

CARLA: Crafty. I love it! *(she chuckles, enjoying the story)*

HEATHER: **(Pg 18)** He started telling her things about us. About me. How he wasn't finding me attractive anymore. Horrible things. **(Pg 24)** I've had enough. I want him gone. Completely. And you're the only person I know who can do it. Kill him. Kill Simon. I want him dead. *(deep breath)* You've done it before.

CARLA: To a pigeon! A pigeon! What's wrong with you?! *(Stands to leave, Heather rises also)*

HEATHER: I've got ten thousand in this bag. And there's another twenty once it's done. Thirty grand. **(Pg 25)** It's a load of money.

CARLA: Well, not really . . . actually.

HEATHER: It is when you have nothing.

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CARLA: *(Angry)* That would be none of your business.

HEATHER: **(Pg 26-27)** Look at you pretending. As if thirty grand isn't something you're desperate for.

CARLA: I don't know who you think I am . . .

HEATHER: You're scrabbling. In the dirt. You're nothing. You'd do anything to get out of here. For your kids. Thirty grand could relocate you all. Move to a different city. Start again. You need this.

CARLA: You're wrong. **** you. You're wrong. *(Carla leaves, a long beat and she returns)* Thirty grand?

******Scene Break*******

Heather's house. Upper class. On the wall is a collection of Tarantula Hawk Wasps on display under glass. Heather is preparing tea and biscuits when Carla arrives.

HEATHER: **(Pg 28)** *(Doorbell – Heather answers and leads Carla into the living room)* Shoes off if you don't mind. *(Carla removes her shoes while Heather pours tea)*

CARLA: **(Pg 30-31)** So I was thinking we make it look like a botched burglary. *(she picks up and examines something from a side table)* I'll take some stuff . . . It'll look more authentic that way. *(Heather hands Carla a teacup and they both sip during the following conversation)*

HEATHER: I'd rather not lose any belongings. I mean, I'm already paying you an awful lot.

CARLA: You want me to kill your husband and you're worrying about losing your DVD Player?

HEATHER: **(Pg 32)** If you do a burglary, you could leave evidence.

CARLA: **(Pg 31)** Well, you come up with something then. *(Carla sips her tea)*

HEATHER: Actually, I have. I cook him a lovely meal and slip something in his drink *(Heather watches Carla takes another sip of tea and smiles knowingly)* that sedates him. Once he's out, I call you and that's when you kill him.

CARLA: **(Pg 36-37)** *(pause in the conversation as Carla wanders around the living room drinking her tea. She spots the wasp display on the wall)* Weird thing to have on your wall.

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HEATHER: Yeh, well, that's Simon. Ever the enthusiast. It's a wasp called a Tarantula Hawk. It preys on [tarantulas]. It paralyses them. Plants an egg on it which burrows into it and grows feeding off its insides, but avoiding the major organs so it's still alive.

CARLA: Bit like being pregnant.

HEATHER: What? Being eaten from the inside out? *(Heather laughs inappropriately)*

CARLA: May as well be. *(Heather pours more tea for Carla – awkward silence)* **(Pg 39)** This all feels very chummy doesn't it? It's funny, I didn't expect that we would be getting on. We're so different. *(beat, then somewhat of an accusation)* I spent most of my teen years severely depressed. I just want you to know that.

CARLA: You're saying it like it's my fault.

HEATHER: You don't think it's your fault?

CARLA: No! It was school. I mean come on. Everyone was horrible to everyone.

HEATHER: Not everyone.

CARLA: **(Pg 40)** *(angry)* Yes everyone. You're nothing special, Heather. I dealt with shit too.

HEATHER: **(Pg 41-42)** I spent every lunch time in the art room with Ms. Beacher and every break making sure I avoided you and your gang.

CARLA: You thought you were so much better than me. Teacher pleaser. Goody two shoes. You didn't know what my life had been like, and you judged me every day. You want to know what happened the day I killed the pigeon? I watched my dad smack my mum so hard her eye popped out of its socket. I watched her put it back in while I called an ambulance. I couldn't be your friend. You pissed me off, you and your sunshine family -- my family? A black hole of shit! **(Pg 43)** *(Carla sways slightly; Heather notices and checks her watch).* Are we going to finish talking about the plan? **(Pg 44)** I don't know what [he] looks like. Photo?

HEATHER: *(takes a deep breath and lets it out calmy; she appears sufficiently chastised by Carla's outburst)* **(Pg 45)** I made you a pack of photos and information. It's in the desk *(motions to the desk)* You grab it and I'll tidy up.

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Carla drains the last of her tea and holds it out to Heather as if she were the maid; Heather takes it, eyes down. Carla sways again as she turns to the desk. Out of Carla's line of sight, Heather takes latex gloves from her pocket and puts them on. She takes a vial of liquid from her pocket and dampens a handkerchief. She stands watching Carla and waiting.

CARLA: *(looking through the envelope, she is shocked. Slurring her words)* This is . . . this is James.

HEATHER: *(sweetly)* No. His name is Simon. You must know that men who visit prostitutes don't use their real name. He's been visiting you for a couple of years now – quite heavily around seven months ago. *(In one step Heather quickly grabs Carla who is still processing what's going on, places the handkerchief over her mouth and holds it there until Carla passes out)*

******Scene Break*******

(Pg 47) *(Carla is sitting on a chair, hands and feet bound with plastic ties. She is gagged. Heather produces some smelling salts and waves it under Carla's nose. She wakes and reacts aggressively, but is too restrained to do much)*

HEATHER: **(Pg 49)** I'll remove the gag shortly. I just want some space for my words first. *(coldy)* **(Pg 42)** I knew about your dad. I'd seen your bruises. **(Pg 43)** [But] I'd never even been slapped let alone punched before that day. You did it. I couldn't see out of my left eye for two weeks it was so swollen. One minute I'm walking, next I'm on the floor. **(Pg 49)** And you all just stood there looking at me. And that's when you walked over to me and whispered in my ear. *(Heather moves behind Carla and whispers in her ear)* Good girl. *(Briskly, change of tone)* **(Pg 50)** I'm going to remove the gag. This is your opportunity to speak. *(she takes the gag off)* Do you have anything to say?

CARLA: **(Pg 51)** *(frantically)* Are you going to kill me? I'm really sorry, but I was f*** up myself. I didn't know what I was doing and I didn't know right from wrong and I'm sorry, I am I'm really really sorry. I don't know what else to say, but please don't hurt me or my baby. Please.

HEATHER: **(Pg 52)** *(laughs bitterly)* I can't believe I've actually made Carla Jackson cry. Actually you almost derailed all of this when we first met. When you offered me your child.

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CARLA: You can have it. You can. **(Pg 53)** It's his kid, Heather. You know it and I know it. So if you want [it] then it's yours.

HEATHER: **(Pg 54-55)** *(laughs again)* Oh, sweetheart! I wish I could find some empathy somewhere. I know I should be looking at your background and excusing your behaviour as a symptom. I was just caught in the crossfire wasn't I. And yet . . . What if I told you that Simon was dead already? That I'd hacked him to death in a bit of a jealous rage and he is currently in the freezer until I work out what to do with him. *(Heather picks up a large kitchen knife from a table behind Carla)* And what if I told you that I was planning on using this knife to extract the baby from your stomach while you were still alive. You said yourself you don't want the child. What's the problem?

CARLA: You're insane! Let me go! LET ME GO! Help me! Help!

HEATHER: There is an impact to everything a person does. Even a single word can have an effect. *(Heather's phone rings and it snaps her out of her mania. She looks at the message and makes a decision. She shakily puts the knife down on the floor)* **(Pg 57)** I'm going to undo the hand and foot ties. *(She takes a pair of scissors and cuts the plastic ties)* I'm trusting you not to run.

CARLA: *(Carla lunges for the knife and hold it out in front of her to keep Heather at bay) (Sarcastically – she believes she has the upper hand now)* **(Pg 59)** You're more insane than I thought you were.

HEATHER: **(Pg 56)** *(softly)* I've always found the idea of revenge repulsive. I find the threat of violence worse. *(calmly)* **(Pg 59)** By freeing you I have given you two opportunities. Kindness or violence? Which one are you going to choose?

CARLA: *(a beat then plunges the knife into heather's chest – Heather smiles)* **(Pg 60)** Why are you smiling? *(She hears a noise off stage, a door opening)* Who's that? Who's that? [Simon?} You said he was dead. What have you done? They'll think it was all me. Heather, what have you done?

HEATHER: Good girl . . . . *(louder)* Good girl. *(Heather collapses)*

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